Zechariah's Eight Night Visions

a Four Horsemen (1:8)

b Four Horns and Four Smiths (1:18)

b Man with the Measuring Cord (2:1)

c Joshua, the High Priest (3:1)

c Zerubbabel, the Governor (4:1)

b Flying Scroll (5:1)

b Woman in the Basket (5:5)

a Four Chariots (6:1)

The eight night visions are arranged in a chiastic structure, which emphasizes the center of the structure (i.e., the visions about Joshua and Zerubbabel).

1 - The Four Horsemen

(1:7-17)

The riders (probably depicting angelic beings) are modeled after the Persian dispatches, well-known throughout the empire (cf. Est. 1:22; 3:13, 15; 8:10, 14).

- *They reported to the Mal'ak Yahweh that political and military conflict had subsided.*
- *However, this state of peace had not resulted in the restoration of Jerusalem and Judah.*

Nevertheless, Yahweh's passion was deeply stirred, both in anger at the nations for their treatment of his people and in eagerness for the holy city and temple to be rebuilt.

- *Yahweh had once chosen Mt. Zion in the time of David (Ps. 68:15-18; 78:67-72; 132:13-18).*
- *Now, he would chose it again (1:17)!*

If God's passion was so aroused, how could the passion of the remnant be any less?

Toy-sized horses and riders are common archaeological finds from the Persian Period, when Persian couriers were common as the provincial communication system for the empire.

2 - Four Horns and Four Smiths

(1:18-21)

Canaanite

Israelite

Bull horns were a common symbol of power in the ancient Near East, either the power of a political entity or the power of the patron god of a city or state (cf. Da. 7:24; Ps. 132:17).

Babylonian

Persian

The four horns symbolize the nations that exiled Israel. If the four smiths symbolize the nations that conquered the horns (nations) that exiled Israel, the possible interpretations are:

Symbolic	Israel & Judah	Judah only	As in Daniel
Oppressors	**Oppressors**	**Oppressors**	**Oppressors**
Assyria & Babylon	Assyria (Israel) Egypt (Jehoahaz) Babylon (Jehoiachin) Persia (pogrom)	Babylon Persia Greece Rome	Babylon Persia Greece Rome
Conquered by	**Conquered by**	**Conquered by**	**Conquered by**
Babylon & Persia and their cohorts (here the number "4" simply means "all")	Babylon Persia Greece Rome	Persia Greece Rome Kingdom of God	Messianic kingdom

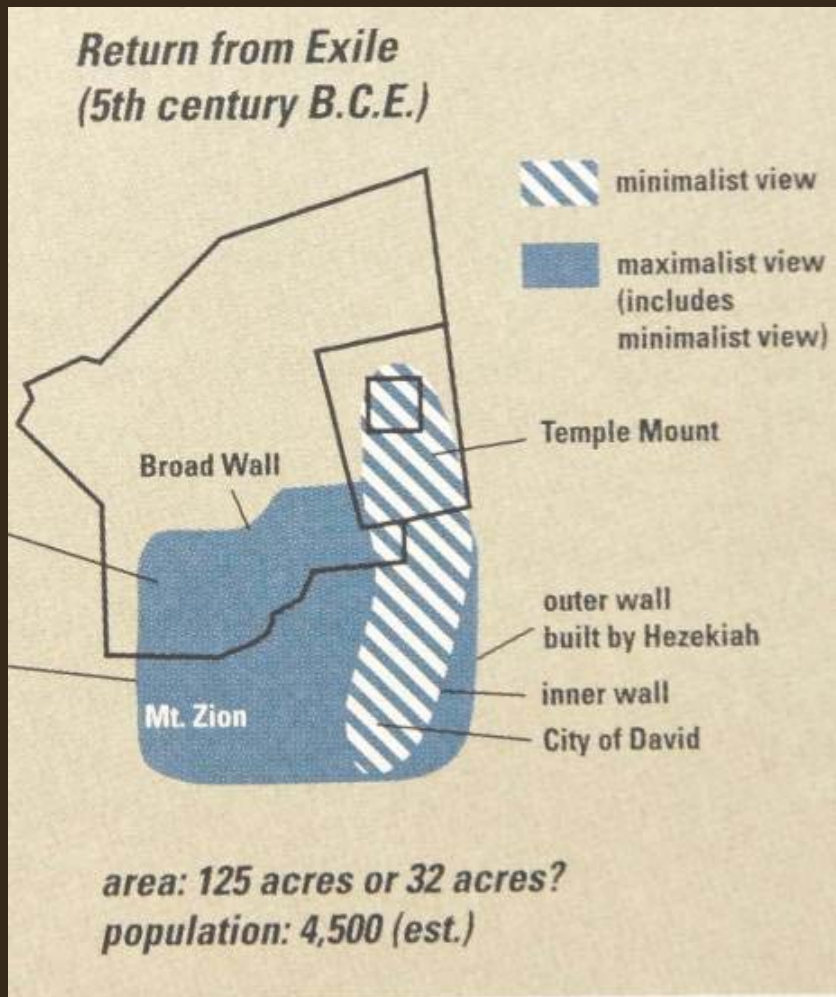
3 – The Surveyor

The man with the measuring cord (2:1-2), like the man with the measuring rod in Ezekiel's vision (Eze. 40:3), presumably intends to survey the city so that the work of rebuilding may continue.

THE MESSAGE:

Jerusalem would be so heavily populated that it could have no walls. It would be protected by a "wall of fire," as in the exodus (Ex. 13:21-22; 40:38), and God's glory would be within it.

Hence, rebuilding the 2nd Temple was part of a much grander future in God's larger purpose.



Jerusalem's Future Included the Nations (2:6-13)

In an oracle, the Jews remaining in Babylon and Persia are urged to "come out" (2:6).

- *The lands of Babylon and Persia were now under judgment, for Zechariah had been commissioned to preach judgment against the nations plundering Jerusalem (2:7-9)*
- *In the end, Yahweh himself promised to come and live among them (2:10).*
- *Many from among the nations would also be joined to the remnant of Israel so that together they will be his people (2:11-12).*

The rebuilding of the temple was part of this international future!

4 - The Heavenly Court Scene (3:1-5)

The accused, Joshua, the High Priest

- *As the High Priest, Joshua stood as the representative of the remnant community.*
- *His filthy robes symbolized the sins of the nation, and as their representative, he bore the uncleanness of the people.*

The prosecutor, הַשָּׂטָן (= Satan, the Accuser)

- *As in the Book of Job, the name "satan" is not used here as a proper name (i.e., it has no definite article in the Hebrew text)*

The defense, the מַלְאַךְ יְהוָה (= Messenger of Yahweh)

- *The Mal'ak Yahweh speaks both as Yahweh's representative and as Yahweh himself.*
- *The rebuke, "Yahweh rebuke you", parallels the rebuke of Michael (Jude 9).*

The New Commission (3:6-10)

After the celestial Judge exonerated Joshua and cleansed him by a divine act (3:3-5), he was commissioned anew.

- *He was charged to keep the Torah, and when he did, he would be given immediate access to God like the angels (i.e., he would be "among those who stand here", that is, the heavenly beings).*
- *Joshua and his fellow priests were symbols of things to come, one of which was the advent of God's servant "the Branch" (cf. Is. 4:2-6; 11:1ff.; Je. 23:5-6; 33:15-16).*
- *The stone with its seven facets (possibly the diadem in the priest's turban) symbolized the cleansing of guilt from the land in a single day.*

The rebuilding of the temple was linked to this messianic future!